

Privacy Silence: Trust and Boundary-Setting in Mobile Phone Use Within Intimate Relationships

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Abstract

Privacy in intimate partnerships involves balancing personal autonomy with information sharing. Mobile phones, as personal yet relational tools, highlight the tension between openness and boundary maintenance. While much recent research has focused on toxic behaviors such as cyberstalking and technology-facilitated abuse, there has been less exploration of privacy practices in everyday relationships that are not characterized by unhealthy dynamics. To address this gap, we conducted 20 semi-structured interviews examining privacy boundary-setting in current or past relationships. Our findings reveal that many individuals opt for silence over direct confrontation, leading to the emergence of what we term "privacy silence"—a non-verbal approach to managing privacy that reflects and reinforces trust within intimate relationships. We advocate for developing privacy dialogue methods that encourage open, collaborative conversations about boundaries, fostering trust and mutual understanding without placing the burden on one partner or implying mistrust.

CCS Concepts

• **Security and privacy** → **Social aspects of security and privacy**; Security requirements; • **Social and professional topics** → *Privacy policies*.

Keywords

Intimate Partner, Privacy, Mobile phone, Intimate Partner Surveillance/Abuse/Violence

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1 Introduction

Digital privacy has been studied extensively through frameworks like the privacy calculus [23], which examines trade-offs between privacy concerns and service benefits, and Nissenbaum's Contextual Integrity [28, 29], which highlights privacy as context-dependent and shaped by societal norms. However, much of this research adopts individualistic perspectives, often overlooking the relational and dynamic aspects of privacy [26, 39].

In intimate partnerships, privacy negotiations are particularly complex due to the multi-faceted nature of these relationships. Unlike relationships which have relatively clear boundaries (e.g., employer-employee), intimate partnerships span emotional, physical, and psychological dimensions, complicating decisions about what should remain private or be shared [22, 32, 36].

Mobile phones amplify these challenges by providing access to sensitive information such as private messages, personal photos, and browsing histories [27, 45]. In toxic relationships, research shows that mobile phones are often used as tools for surveillance and control, enabling behaviors like monitoring activities, tracking locations, and accessing personal messages without consent [7, 25, 27].

Despite this, the privacy practices and boundary negotiation in everyday relationships remain under-explored. Understanding these practices in non-toxic, day-to-day interactions is crucial to gaining a fuller picture of how partners navigate digital privacy in intimate settings [9, 34].

To address the gap we identify above, we conducted semi-structured interviews with 20 mobile device users to explore **how partners navigate conflicts between individuals and the management of their privacy needs in the context of mobile phone use, as well as how they communicate their boundaries, desires, and expectations**.

Our preliminary findings introduce the concept of *privacy silence*, a practice where partners intentionally refrain from discussing mobile phone privacy. This silence functions as a subtle yet powerful

way of communicating trust, as partners rely on unspoken norms rather than explicit agreements. Based on our study, we identified four reasons for this silence: (1) the absence of privacy boundaries altogether, (2) an implicit respect for unspoken privacy boundaries, (3) fear that explicit discussions could generate mistrust, and (4) concerns that such discussions might harm the relationship, self-image, or social standing.

We discuss the implications of privacy silence for future research on privacy practices in intimate relationships, proposing strategies to encourage open dialogue about mobile device privacy. By fostering openness and vulnerability, such dialogue can help partners navigate complex privacy issues, reduce risk of boundary breaches, and arguably strengthen relationships.

2 Related Work

The growing integration of technology into daily life has intensified privacy concerns, particularly regarding mobile platforms [40]. The COVID-19 pandemic further influenced privacy dynamics, with social isolation emerging as a factor affecting privacy management—especially around behaviors like sexting among individuals experiencing varying degrees of isolation [8]. The concept of the “privacy paradox” sheds light on the complex relationship between privacy concerns and the protective actions individuals take to safeguard their information [24]. In romantic relationships, managing confidential information and sharing personal data significantly impacts trust and overall relationship quality [10]. Additionally, research on privacy protection strategies in social media environments provides valuable insights into the factors that shape privacy-related decisions [37].

Privacy, online and offline, has been analyzed through various theoretical frameworks [12, 23, 38, 44]. In commercial contexts, the privacy calculus [23] examines how individuals balance privacy concerns against service benefits. Behavioral economic models expand on this by considering how cognitive biases and bounded rationality influence decision-making, particularly in phenomena like the privacy paradox [1, 2, 30].

Individualistic approaches, however, fall short in addressing privacy within intimate relationships, where emotions, negotiable norms, and contingent dynamics are central. Boundary regulation theory [4, 44] better captures this complexity, framing privacy as a process of negotiating interpersonal boundaries to balance autonomy and connection [44]. Another influential privacy theory is that of Nissenbaum’s Contextual Integrity theory [28, 29] which emphasizes that privacy is socially embedded and governed by dynamic, context-dependent norms shaped by power relations. This theory emphasizes privacy’s normative nature, highlighting that privacy is not solely the result of individual decisions but is deeply socially embedded, where information flow practices must align with the established social norms governing that context. These norms are not fixed but context-dependent and dynamic. As Nissenbaum stressed, “when we mind that information about us is shared, we mind not simply that it is being shared but that it is shared in the wrong ways and with inappropriate others. Although most of the time these requirements are tacit and the states of all parameters need not be tediously spelled out, in controversial cases, elliptical expressions of people’s expectations can be taken too literally and serve as sources

of common misunderstandings” [29]. In this context, Berkholz et al. [9] highlight that privacy norms are typically taken for granted and governed by unwritten rules that guide social interactions and behavior. Drawing on the work of Garfinkel [15], they argue that these implicit norms commonly become apparent only in situations where breaches occur, prompting reflection and articulation of these rules.

Petronio’s [34] Communication Privacy Management (CPM) Theory further expands on the concept of boundary regulation, particularly in the context of families and partnerships. In such settings, intimate relationships constitute distinct social systems, necessitating the consideration of two primary processes of boundary regulation [44]. Regarding the boundary between the family system and the external, public environment, what information is shared externally and what is kept private within the family must be regulated. For example, there are (often implicit) rules and expectations within the family to what extent internal family issues are shared with externals [34]. Internal boundary regulation has been primarily studied in the context of parent-child relationships, where the balance between parental authority and the child’s need for privacy and autonomy is central [26]. While research often emphasizes these parent-child dynamics or toxic relationships with boundary violations [26, 39], boundary regulation between partners in healthy relationships remains under-explored. Far less is known about how privacy boundaries and norms are negotiated in healthy/non-toxic relationships. Yet, as Petronio [35] notes, even in non-toxic partnerships, boundary regulation is essential for navigating privacy, mutual respect, and relational balance. Understanding the dynamics of boundary regulation in healthy partnerships could offer valuable insights into how partners navigate privacy, maintain mutual respect, and foster relational balance in day-to-day life. As Petronio notes: “If a person refuses to tell a romantic partner about his or her relational history, the partner might claim an intention to deceive. However, the person may argue that he or she has a right to keep such information private and not reveal the romantic partners” [35].

2.1 Mobile Phone Boundary Regulation

The HCI community has increasingly focused on understanding how technology, including mobile devices, influences intimate partner privacy. Mobile phones are not merely personal assistants or communication tools. They also serve as instruments for maintaining relationships. Social media research [37], for instance, provides valuable insights into decision-making processes involved in information sharing with others. In romantic relationships, the sharing of personal data plays a pivotal role in shaping trust and overall relationship quality [10]. Mobile devices can facilitate intimacy and connection, enabling instant communication and emotional closeness [27]. During the COVID-19 pandemic activities such as sexting via mobile devices served as a coping mechanism to alleviate the effects of social isolation [8]. The implications of mobile phone use in intimate relationships encompass critical issues of digital privacy and safety [3, 7]. Mobile devices can both empower and control individuals, particularly in relationships, as noted by Gibbs et al. [16, 17] who point to the way in which they can in some circumstances result in increased surveillance and control by partners.

This dual role underscores the need to address the balance between privacy and transparency in intimate partnerships. Similarly, Ngcongco [27] emphasizes that the way mobile devices can enable constant connection introduces new challenges, such as increased expectations for availability, over-monitoring, and potential trust breaches. Partners who choose to keep certain matters private are often expected to justify their reasons for doing so [33, 41]. However, individual autonomy remains crucial, and certain personal thoughts or experiences may need to remain private to preserve a sense of self [7].

Bellini et al. [8] and Petronio [34] note that boundaries are often unintentionally violated due to a lack of awareness or misunderstanding of contextual privacy norms. This is particularly common during transitions in relationship statuses (e.g., the beginning of a relationship or a breakup), changes in life circumstances (e.g., someone becoming a caregiver or care recipient), or the adoption of new technologies (e.g., smart devices). This dual role highlights the delicate balance between personal independence and shared intimacy in close relationships, emphasizing the dynamic and ever-changing nature of boundary regulation. Given this fluidity, trust can be problematized. The breaching of trust includes less overtly harmful behaviors, such as checking each other's phones or accessing accounts without consent [27, 45]. At the extreme end of the spectrum, technology can facilitate abuse, control, and surveillance in intimate partner relationships. Matthews et al. [25] explored the coping strategies of survivors of intimate partner abuse (IPA), while Freed et al. [13, 14] analyzed the ecosystem surrounding intimate partner violence (IPV), highlighting how technology facilitates both control and abuse. These studies underscore how mobile devices can enable domestic violence, stalking, and intimate partner surveillance (IPS), exposing the urgent need for safeguards to mitigate such risks. Hence, Freed et al. [13] further called for improvements to ensure intimate partners' safety by mitigating the risks posed by digital tools. Additionally, Bellini et al. [8] examined intimate partner surveillance (IPS), showing how mobile devices can be used to undermine privacy through monitoring and control.

Nevertheless, the focus by existing research on extreme cases of abuse has to some extent overlooked the everyday privacy violations that occur in less overtly harmful contexts [8, 21, 43, 45]. Amirkhani et al. [7] argue that these everyday privacy boundaries are equally important, emphasizing that privacy violations can occur even outside of abusive situations. They require constant negotiation. However, these boundaries are rarely explicitly discussed, leading to implicit norms shaped by each partner's views on intimacy, trust, and autonomy [8]. Ngcongco [27] emphasizes that while regulations can promote privacy, mobile device use can blur personal boundaries when partners engage in intrusive behaviors, such as checking each other's phones or accessing accounts without consent [45]. To negotiate privacy boundaries effectively, Ngcongco [27] further stresses that constructive discussions foster respect and trust. Balancing closeness and autonomy requires partners to agree on which boundaries are respected and which matters remain undisclosed [14]. Misalignments in privacy expectations can cause misunderstandings [7]. Lack of communication or negative interactions often intensifies conflicts [11, 19]. Amirkhani et al. [7] emphasize that these overlooked daily negotiations are crucial for

understanding privacy as a relational practice. Despite their importance, privacy conversations practice studies between intimate partners remain largely unexplored, underscoring the need to better understand how couples navigate these discussions to promote healthier relationship dynamics.

3 Method

3.1 Participant Recruitment and Data Collection

Ethical approval was obtained from the university's ethics board. Participants were recruited based on three criteria: ownership of a personal mobile phone, self-identification as active mobile phone users, and being over 18 years old. The age criterion ensured participants were ethically eligible for intimate partnerships and capable of providing informed consent. All participants were either currently or recently in a relationship, with ages ranging from 22 to 44 years (13 Female (F), 6 Male (M), 1 Non Binary (NB)).

Recruitment was conducted through multiple channels specifically through Telegram channels, the researchers' personal networks, and participant referrals. Although the study was conducted in Germany, participants represented diverse cultural backgrounds, including Italy, Iran, India, China, Germany, Mexico, Thailand, Syria, Afghanistan, Azerbaijan, Pakistan, Ghana, Indonesia, and New Zealand. Educational levels ranged from bachelor's degree holders to PhD candidates. The relationship status of participants varied, including individuals who were single, in a relationship, married, divorced, or had recently experienced a breakup, contributing to a comprehensive understanding of relationship dynamics and mobile phone privacy concerns. Table 1 provides an overview of participants' demographic details, including gender, age, nationality and status.

3.2 Semi-structured Interviews

Before the interviews, participants provided informed consent, confirming their understanding of the study's purpose and confidentiality measures. The semi-structured interviews followed a framework covering nine key areas: demographic details, relationship history, mobile phone usage, privacy in relationships, privacy conflicts, strategies for communication, handling privacy breaches, impacts of smartphones on privacy, and general opinions or suggestions. Some questions included: 1) Which parts of your mobile phone do you consider the most private, and why? (e.g., location, gallery, chats) 2) Do you discuss mobile phone privacy with your intimate partner? If so, how often? 3) Have you ever experienced conflicts with your partner regarding mobile phone privacy? If so, can you provide an example?, and 4) If your partner asks to access the private part of your phone, how would you react?

We offered participants both online and offline interview sessions. However, all preferred online sessions. Interviews were conducted via platforms like Telegram and WhatsApp, allowing participants to choose their preferred format—voice, video, or text-based communication. This flexibility was offered due to the sensitivity of the topic for some participants. Several participants expressed discomfort with the idea of their partner overhearing their perspectives during the interview. For these participants, text-based

Table 1: Participant Demographics

Participant	Gender	Age	Status	Participant	Gender	Age	Status
P1	F	31	In relationship	P11	F	27	Divorced
P2	M	34	Single	P12	F	27	Single
P3	F	37	Broke up	P13	F	23	In relationship
P4	M	40	Married	P14	F	27	In relationship
P5	M	36	Married	P15	F	29	Married
P6	M	22	In relationship	P16	F	28	In relationship
P7	F	27	Married	P17	F	38	Married
P8	M	38	Broke up	P18	F	38	Broke up
P9	F	44	Married	P19	M	32	Broke up
P10	NB	28	In relationship	P20	F	31	Broke up

interviews were arranged to ensure their privacy and respect their comfort [5].

The interviews ranged from 17 to 40 minutes, depending on the level of detail participants were willing to share. All interviews were transcribed verbatim for analysis with the consent of participants. To protect participant privacy, identities were anonymized, and data was securely stored to prevent unauthorized access.

3.3 Data Analysis

We conducted a qualitative content analysis (QCA) [18, 20], a widely utilized method in qualitative research, using MAXQDA software for data coding [6]. The first and second authors carried out multiple rounds of reading to develop initial codes and themes. Subsequently, the remaining authors contributed by refining these themes and identifying additional ones, in collaboration with the first two authors. Through this process, we identified a core theme, "Privacy Silence," which was further divided into categories such as "factors contributing to silence", "privacy mismatches", "cultural and normative influences", and "trust barriers". In this initial analysis, we focus solely on one primary category: "factors contributing to privacy silence".

4 Preliminarily Findings

In the interviews, it became evident that participants rarely discussed boundaries and protecting their mobile privacy with their partners. This was not solely due to the absence of concrete occasions in daily life. The conversations reflected that there are deeper reasons for this reluctance. A central motive that emerged was a noticeable hesitation to *initiate* such discussions. We use the term "privacy silence" to describe this phenomenon. It refers to the deliberate or unintentional avoidance of conversations about personal boundaries and privacy within intimate relationships.

Privacy silence is not merely the absence of communication about privacy; it encapsulates the complex interplay of emotions, perceptions, and relational dynamics, highlighting the sensitivities involved in boundary regulation within intimate partnerships. For instance, P11 explained, *"I trust her completely, so why would we need to talk about privacy?"* This response illustrates how avoiding explicit discussions about privacy boundaries can serve as an expression of trust, with such conversations perceived as unnecessary in a relationship deemed secure.

P1 expressed a similar sentiment: *"We trust each other, so I feel like discussing privacy would just complicate things unnecessarily"* (P1). Here, privacy conversations are framed not only as superfluous but

also as potentially counter-productive making everything complicated. Moreover, talking about privacy might touch cultural norms as stressed by P12: *"Talking about privacy feels like I'm questioning our trust, and that's just not how relationships work in my culture"* (P12).

A closer examination of privacy silence reveals subtle distinctions in the relationship between privacy boundaries and trust. In this context, trust may suggest that no explicit privacy boundaries exist between partners, leading to silence. Alternatively, it may indicate the presence of unspoken privacy boundaries that partners trust will be respected, allowing them to remain silent. In both cases, privacy silence emerges as an expression of trust within the partnership.

In the following sections, we will explore four different reasons, drawn from the empirical data, that participants identified as contributing to privacy silence in the context of boundary regulation.

4.1 There Are No Boundaries To Regulate

One reason for privacy silence was that some participants did not perceive a need to discuss privacy boundaries, as they believed no such boundaries should exist within an intimate relationship. P5 encapsulated this perspective, stating, *"I don't think about privacy much—it's just not a big deal in an intimate relationship"* (P5). This sentiment reflects a view in which the absence of privacy concerns is interpreted as a positive indicator of the relationship's strength.

P2 has similar view, stating *"Privacy concerns feel overblown to me. We're in a relationship; what's there to hide?"* (P2). In this case, the importance of privacy is downplayed within the context of an intimate relationship. The lack of communication about privacy reflects a perceived minimal need to address the issue, driven by the belief that the associated risks were insignificant.

In such cases the privacy silence reflects an idealization of relationships as spaces of total openness and unreserved trust, where the concept of personal boundaries is seen as irrelevant or even contradictory to the essence of intimacy.

4.2 Boundaries Are Known, And Will Be Respected

Several participants did not perceive a need to articulate boundaries—not because these boundaries did not exist, but because they believed such boundaries were implicitly understood within the intimate relationship. This implicit understanding is captured in P7's comment: *"We don't really talk about it because I think he [their partner] knows what's okay for me and what's not"* (P7). Similarly, P3 described this dynamic as *"It's like an unspoken agreement—we just*

know what we're comfortable with" (P3). This reliance on implied agreements highlights a preference for unspoken boundaries over direct communication.

In these cases, privacy norms are not explicitly negotiated but operate as tacit understandings and background expectancies. Here, the privacy silence presents an efficient mechanism for boundary regulation in daily routines by creating an illusion of stability, where privacy norms function smoothly in the background, guided by mutual, tacit understanding. However, their fragility lies in their invisibility; when situations change and privacy expectations are unintentionally breached, verbalizing norms and explicit acknowledgment become necessary.

4.3 Making Boundaries Explicit Might Generate Mistrust

Some participants avoided making boundaries explicit, as raising privacy issues could be interpreted as a sign of mistrust or secrecy. This latent fear is exemplified in the interview with P9, who stated, *"If I ask about privacy, it sounds like I'm hiding something or accusing my partner of hiding something"* (P9). Similarly, P10 expressed a comparable sentiment: *"Raising these topics makes me feel like I'm being overly suspicious, and I don't want them [their partner] to think that of me"* (P10). These quotes underscore the fear of being perceived as un-trusting, which kept participants silent about their concerns. In this context, privacy silence is closely tied to individuals' self-perception, driving them to align their actions with their self-concept as a trusting and reliable partner.

This underscores the delicate balance participants navigate between addressing privacy concerns and preserving both their self-image and the image of the relationship, with the latter often taking precedence.

4.4 Touching Boundaries Might Cause Harm

Participants frequently avoided privacy discussions because they feared these conversations might lead to damage to their relationships. In our interview, P4 expressed the fear of challenging harmony within the relationship *"If I bring up privacy, it feels like I'm accusing them of something, and it just creates tension"* (P4). This quote highlights the emotional costs of raising sensitive topics such as privacy. This is also because privacy boundaries are not merely neutral demarcations of personal space; they are deeply embedded in the power structures, socio-cultural norms, and personal expectations within a relationship. These boundaries are often fragile, unspoken, and represent messy compromises, making them both adaptable and highly susceptible to rupture.

This becomes particularly evident in P8's statement, noting *"Talking about privacy always feels like opening a can of worms. I'd rather not go there and keep things peaceful"* (P8). The metaphor "opening a can of worms" suggests that privacy discussions are perceived as inherently messy and likely to lead to unintended consequences. For P8, addressing privacy boundaries introduces the risk of exposing underlying tensions or unresolved issues that could disrupt the relationship's equilibrium. P8's preference to *"keep things peaceful"* highlights the prioritization of relational harmony over the resolution of privacy concerns. This reflects a dynamic where individuals

suppress or avoid articulating their own demands as this could challenge the status quo, choosing short-term stability over potentially uncomfortable but constructive conversations.

In a similar manner, the term *"disrespectful"* in the quote, *"In our community, you don't talk about these things. It's seen as disrespectful (P6)"* highlights that boundary regulation is more than a neutral exchange of arguments. Rather, the use of the term suggests that privacy talks are perceived as an aggressive rejection — not just against the individual, but also against the cultural norms and values that underpin the relationship dynamics within the community.

The perception of privacy talks as disrespectful reinforces privacy silence, as individuals fear being labelled as disruptive or confrontational. This silence sustains the status quo, where boundaries remain unspoken and are governed by fragile compromises, carrying the risk of breaching personal expectations and autonomy.

4.5 Discussion And Conclusion

Our study uncovers the phenomenon of "privacy silence" in the context of discussing and negotiating privacy boundaries within intimate partnerships. The reasons for this 'silence' are varied and have to do with what we mean by trust in the first place.

Raising the issue of privacy boundaries is a prime example of the kind of breach that Garfinkel identified as simultaneously revealing the solidity and fragility of cultural norms [15]. Our respondents indicated that avoiding discussions about privacy boundaries is often not due to a lack of trust but rather because, in the normal flow of their everyday lives, nothing has occurred to challenge or necessitate such conversations. In this sense, participants avoided privacy discussions because they either perceived boundaries as non-existent or took them for granted. At the same time, they also sought to avoid potential breaches that could disrupt these implicit assumptions and bring them into question.

Nevertheless, occasions may arise, even in the most stable of relationships, when reasons to distrust may arise. It is obvious that relationships do not turn from 'normal' to 'toxic' overnight. Our study demonstrates that privacy issues arise within intimate partnerships as occasioned matters. The diffuse nature of the expressive relationships we describe mean that these occasions will be highly contingent, and are nuanced, complex, and emotional. This diffuse nature complicates the process of establishing clear limits on what should be shared or kept private, as these relationships extend into deeply personal realms [22].

As highlighted in our study, sharing personal information in intimate partnerships is often viewed as a gesture of trust and a means to deepen emotional bonds. Unlike in more defined relationships, where withholding personal details is natural and legally protected, in diffuse relationships, keeping secrets can be perceived as a breach of trust. Our study demonstrates that in this context, discussing privacy boundaries is often avoided due to fears that such conversations might disrupt relationship harmony, will be perceived as a sign of distrust or a lack of love, particularly in relationships that idealize total openness.

Our study shows that this privacy silence does not cause harm because privacy boundaries are not existing or will be respected without making them explicit. This confirms to previous studies on privacy as governed by implicit norms [9, 15]. Yet this silence come

with a risk that boundaries are breached unintentionally or the weaker partner giving up their privacy to avoid relational tensions, or in situations where there are reasons why trust might erode [27].

In order to prevent misunderstandings, and as importantly in order that evolving circumstances can be adapted to by one or both partners, open communication emerged as a key strategy. Cravens et al. [11], for instance, argue that constructive privacy dialogues are essential for maintaining healthy relationships. Moreover, just as society has embraced open conversations about sexuality, it is equally crucial to encourage dialogue about privacy within intimate relationships to prevent issues such as intimate partner surveillance, abuse, and violence possibly arriving without warning [7, 27]. In healthy relationships, in most circumstances, privacy discussions are often viewed as unnecessary or as signals of mistrust in everyday life. Additionally, these conversations are frequently avoided due to fear of conflict. These insights do not only have implications for the design of privacy campaigns, but for the design of privacy mechanisms, too.

Taking our results seriously, it is insufficient to simply provide users with tools to regulate boundaries within partnerships. Instead, in future work such mechanisms should be designed as privacy affordances [31] that facilitate dialogue about privacy expectations and desires in a way that avoids raising mistrust or allows for the recognition of changing boundaries.

4.5.1 Policy Implications for Privacy Silence. The preliminary findings of this analysis suggest future directions for policy reform to better address *privacy silence*. Rather than focusing solely on privacy solutions for established couples, interventions should aim to normalize privacy discussions as an integral part of early relationship-building. When privacy is framed as a routine topic—similar to conversations about personal values, future goals, or relationship expectations—it is less likely to be perceived as a sign of mistrust. Introducing these discussions during the dating stage, when emotional stakes are lower, can help break taboos and make privacy a natural part of relationship dynamics. This shift requires broader societal awareness, reinforcing the idea that discussing privacy is not about suspicion but about fostering mutual understanding and respect.

4.5.2 Next Steps and Future Work. Designing technology that facilitates privacy negotiations at the right stage of a relationship can play a pivotal role in addressing *privacy silence* and maintaining a healthy balance of trust. As part of our future work, we are developing interventions that encourage privacy discussions before trust is fully established, helping to prevent misunderstandings about privacy boundaries and reducing potential conflicts.

One promising approach is integrating privacy discussions into mobile dating platforms. These platforms could incorporate privacy preferences as part of the matching process, allowing users to set and communicate boundaries early on. As relationships progress, apps could introduce periodic prompts to revisit and adjust these preferences, ensuring that privacy remains a shared and evolving conversation. Furthermore, different media types—such as private messages, shared photos, and location tracking—play a significant role in shaping privacy tensions. Future research should explore how digital platforms can implement nuanced privacy controls

that adapt to different communication contexts and media types, helping users navigate boundaries effectively.

Beyond technological solutions, policy initiatives that promote digital literacy and raise awareness about mobile phone-enabled privacy violations (e.g., IPV, IPS, IPA) are crucial. Embedding privacy discussions into both dating experiences and broader societal conversations can empower individuals to proactively shape their digital privacy and establish healthier relationship norms from the outset.

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